

WebApps or native apps?

So should you develop your application as a WebApp or a native app? The answer could be based on the available skill-sets, but here are some pros and cons of both, that you could consider to help you take a better decision. WebApps are developed using HTML, JavaScript and CSS3. Native apps are typically developed using Java on Android.

Aspects in which WebApps score better than native apps

- **App distribution:** A native app needs to be made available through Google Play (formerly Android Market), which is controlled by Google. Other sources require end users to have complete trust in the app gateway and the app you are providing. A WebApp, in contrast, just needs to be hosted on a Web server, and the URL is provided to the user.
- **New releases and patches:** New versions of WebApps can be made available with no extra effort from the end user. A native app requires users to 'update' it (download and install) from Google Play. The end user has to put in much less effort for WebApps.
- **Supporting multiple platforms:** Android comes with a built-in standards-based Web browser. Developing WebApps for this platform will also make the app available on any other mobile platform that has a

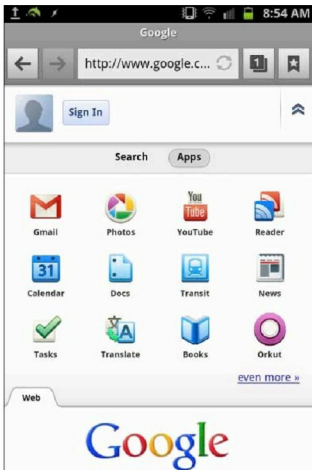


Figure 1: Google WebApps

standards-compliant Web browser, like Safari or Firefox. This aspect could be a major differentiator for WebApps if end users want the service/application to be available on multiple devices that run various different OSs, where native apps must exist and be installed for each, while a single URL to the WebApp works for all.

- **Speed and ease of development:** A WebApp takes considerably less time and effort to develop, compared to a native app. It is easy to get developers with skills in Web technologies.

Aspects where native apps score better

- **Offline usage:** While the HTML5 standard does provide WebApps the capability to store data offline, native apps are ideal for both offline and online purposes. With WebApps, offline storage of data is temporary—when



Figure 2: Citibank Mobile app



Figure 3: Web page on Android browser